



EXPLAINER

What is changing in search, in plain English

A short read for anyone who needs to understand how AI is changing the way visitors find places, without the jargon.

PREPARED BY THE DIGITAL TOURISM THINK TANK

The short version. People are starting to ask AI assistants where to go and what to do, instead of scrolling a list of links. The assistant gives one answer and names a few places. If a business is easy for the assistant to understand and trust, it gets named. If not, it does not. That is the whole shift, and the rest of this explains it.

01 What people are doing now

More than half of travellers have used AI to help plan a trip in the past year, and most who use it act on what it suggests. They type a question in plain words, where can I take the kids near the coast for a rainy afternoon, and read the answer the assistant writes, rather than working through a page of links themselves.

02 The two ways AI shows up

There are two. The first is inside Google: an AI written summary now sits above the usual results, answering the question directly. The second is the assistants themselves, ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity, where the whole experience is a conversation and the answer often names its sources. Both decide which places to mention.

03 Why some places get named and others do not

An assistant recommends what it can understand without effort and trust without contradiction. A business whose information is clear, specific and the same everywhere is easy to name. A business whose details are thin, buried in an image, or different on every site is easy to skip. Size is not the deciding factor. Clarity and consistency are.

04 What it means for a destination

Two things. There is a risk that only the famous names get mentioned and the rest of the destination becomes invisible. And there is an opportunity, because a smaller but genuinely good business can earn its place in the answer simply by being clear and consistent. A destination that helps its whole industry do this spreads visibility rather than concentrating it.

05 What to do about it

The practical steps are not exotic: answer the real questions visitors ask, in plain text on your own pages; keep your facts identical everywhere; and make sure the assistants can read your site. The industry guide sets this out in full, and the member tools help you do and measure it. The point of this explainer is only that the shift is real, and that responding to it is within reach.

06 A few terms, explained

AI assistant. A tool like ChatGPT, Gemini or Perplexity that answers questions in conversation.

AI Overview. The AI written summary at the top of Google's results.

GEO. Generative engine optimisation: making your information easy for these systems to understand and recommend.

Citation. When the assistant names or links your business as a source in its answer.

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